



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



login

login

Medium

Web Exploitation

picoMini by redpwn

AUTHOR: BROWNIEINMOTION

Hints ?

Description

(None)

My dog-sitter's brother made this website but I can't get in; can you help?

login.mars.picoctf.net

54,018 users solved

90% Liked

picoCTF{53rv3r_53rv3r_53rv3r_53rv3r_53rv3r}

Submit Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: login

Category: Web Exploitation

Date: 03/06/26



I. Objective

The objective of this challenge is to analyze a web application and identify hidden information that may reveal the flag. This involves inspecting the website's source code and identifying encoded data that can be decoded to retrieve the flag.

II. Background

In web security challenges, important information is sometimes hidden within the client-side code such as **HTML, CSS, or JavaScript**. Developers may unintentionally leave sensitive data inside these files.

A common technique used in CTF challenges is **encoding**, such as **Base64**, which hides readable information but does not actually secure it. Anyone who finds the encoded text can easily decode it using tools or command-line utilities.

By inspecting the source code and decoding any suspicious strings, attackers or security researchers can reveal hidden messages or flags.

III. Tool Used

- **Web Browser** - Used to access and interact with the challenge website.
- **Browser Developer Tools (Inspect Element)** - Used to analyze the website structure and locate embedded scripts or hidden content.
- **Base64 Decoder** - Used to decode encoded strings discovered in the JavaScript source code.

IV. Methodology

1. Accessed the provided web link for the challenge.

login.mars.picoctf.net

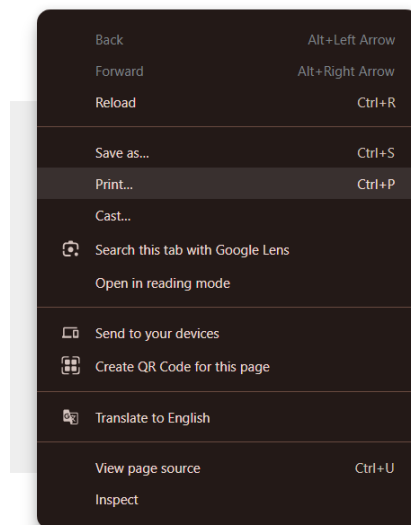


2. Attempted to log in through the website interface, but login was not possible as indicated by the challenge description.

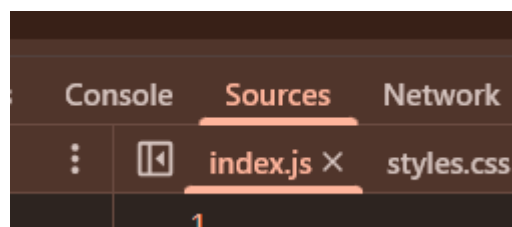
Description

My dog-sitter's brother made this website but I can't get in; can you help?

3. Opened the **Developer Tools** by right-clicking on the webpage and selecting **Inspect**.



4. Navigated to the **Sources** tab to view the website's JavaScript files.

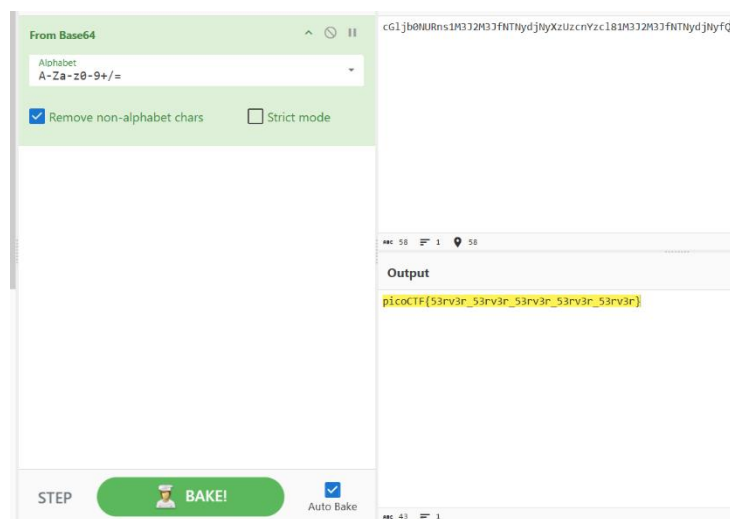




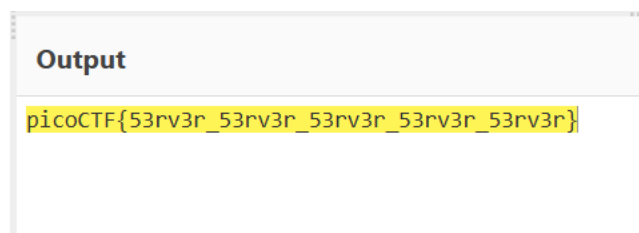
5. Carefully examined the JavaScript code and identified a suspicious **encoded string**.

```
ace(/=/g, '');  
"cG1jb0NURns1M3J2M3JfNTNydjNyXzUzcnYzc181M3J2M3JfNTNydjNyfQ"
```

6. Recognized that the encoded text appeared to be **Base64 encoded data**.
7. Used a **Base64 decoder** to decode the string.



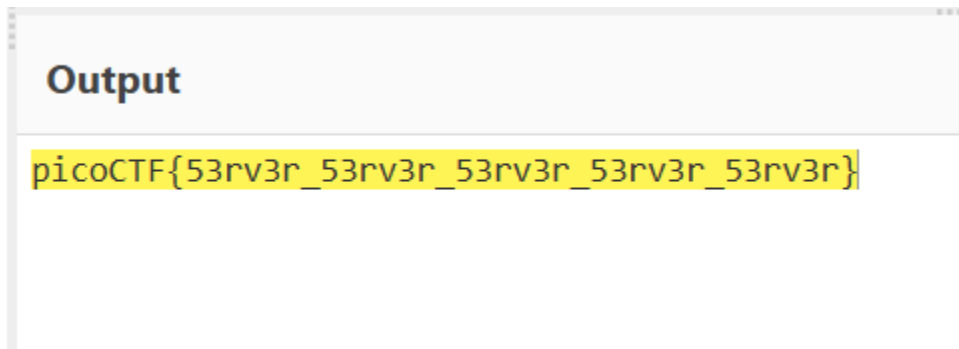
8. The decoded output revealed the **flag**, which was then submitted to the challenge platform.





V. Result

picoCTF{53rv3r_53rv3r_53rv3r_53rv3r_53rv3r}



VI. Explanation

This challenge demonstrates how **sensitive information can be exposed through client-side code**.

Although the login system prevented users from accessing the flag through the interface, the developers left an **encoded string inside the JavaScript file**. Since JavaScript runs on the client side, it is fully visible to anyone inspecting the webpage.

The encoded text was **Base64**, which is not encryption but only a way to represent binary data in text form. Because of this, anyone who discovers the encoded string can easily decode it.

By inspecting the JavaScript file and decoding the Base64 string, the hidden flag was revealed without needing to bypass the login system.



VII. Conclusion

This challenge highlights the importance of **never storing sensitive data in client-side code**. Even if the data is encoded, it can easily be decoded by anyone with access to the page source.

Through careful inspection of the website's JavaScript files and decoding encoded content, the flag was successfully retrieved. This demonstrates how **basic web inspection and understanding encoding techniques** are essential skills in web exploitation and CTF challenges.

— The Analyst: Hyposelenia